

news feed

DIGIT APRIL 2002

hypothesis

SOUNDBUG

■ What is it?

Tagged as the 'sexiest gadget of the year at CeBit', the Soundbug is a device as small as a computer mouse and can turn any flat surface into a soundboard.

■ How does it work?

The Soundbug can be connected to the headphone socket of an MP3 player, Walkman, etc, and then fixed by suction to a flat surface, thereby turning a wall or a window into a speaker. Sound is transmitted to the flat surface via a small piece of Terfenol, a combination of rare earth materials and iron. Terfenol is placed in an aluminium casing, which in turn is wrapped in a coil. Electricity passed through the coil causes the Terfenol to expand, resulting in a force of 400 pounds which causes the surface to vibrate and broadcast the sound.

■ When will it be released?

Soundbug will go on sale sometime in April 2002. It will be priced approximately \$40 (Rs 1,600).

snapshot

2.2%

of the world's population is online

Source: www.ucsi.cc

India to build Supercomputing grid

India's state-run agency for advanced computing, C-DAC, plans to build a nationwide grid of supercomputers for mammoth applications. The grid would be used to aid environmental modelling, fast analysis of satellite images, advanced chip design and simulation of heavy-duty equipment such as turbines.

C-DAC has faced more than a decade of technology export restrictions from the

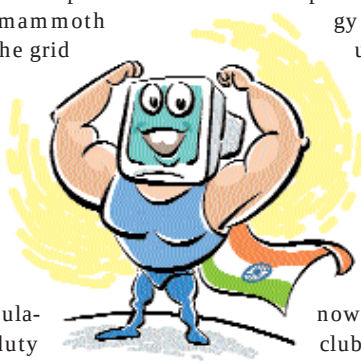
US, particularly relating to the Cray supercomputer on the grounds that India might put the technology to military use. Despite

sanctions, C-DAC has built four versions of its Param series of machines and India is now in the elite club of supercom-

puting nations such as the US, Japan, Israel and China. The latest Param crunches numbers at a speed of 100 gigaflops, or

100 billion floating point operations per second, placing it among the world's top performers, although the US has developed machines that are 10 times faster.

C-DAC's computers, built on a sophisticated clustering of microprocessors, would resemble the popular Napster peer-to-peer file-sharing system, but its scale is humongous and its design intricate, R.K. Arora, Executive Director of C-DAC said. C-DAC plans to link the seven Indian Institutes of Technology (IITs), the Bangalore-based Indian Institute of Science and other academic institutions to the I-Grid.



DivX gets a facelift

DivX Networks released the latest version of its digital video technology, DivX 5.0.



It includes improvements to image quality and compatibility with the MPEG-4 format. DivX 5.0 uses 'psycho-visual modelling', which selects image data in the encoding process based on how people perceive motion, light and colour, and places

that data where the eye is most sensitive to it.

DivX Networks have been struggling to establish a means of making money out of its popularity among video-traders on free peer-to-peer trading networks.

It clocked more than 1 million downloads within 48 hours of its latest release. DivX is trying to go legitimate now, and includes digital rights management, or DRM technology, which would protect movies from being bootlegged.

Foul Play at CeBit?

Reflecting bad gaming spirit, Microsoft played spoilsport and reported on Sony to Hannover Messe AG, the organisers of CeBit. The point of contention was that Sony was breaching show rules by letting people have a go at the Sony PlayStation 2 (PS2) consoles. Technically, Microsoft was right, and Sony had to pack up its 27 PS2s. Sony has shown PlayStation consoles for the past three years without any problem. Microsoft also demonstrated its game machine at the show this year.